

Timeline

A.D. 2068: Bjørnøya Resouce Group (B.R.G.) is tasked to drill for natural gas deposits in the Barents Sea. They build a base of operations on Bear Island on a former weather station.

A.D. 2071: B.R.G. discovers something deep below Bear Island, using new seismic sensor technology. They dig deep and unearth an inexplicably shielded arch, carved into the rock in a prehistoric cavern. What they don't know is that it's a portal to *Vel*, another dimension.

A.D. 2081: B.R.G. scientists manage to create a key (a small chip of a special alloy) that opens the door beneath Bear Island, and begin running a variety of experiments, sending messages and small objects through the door.

A.D. 2082 / Year 0: *The Cataclysm*: A rift opens along the equator, all around the planet, raising the temperature of the planet's atmosphere. This event also ruptures the invisible barrier to allow attunement with the Wake, effectively enabling the use of magic.

Year 0-3: *Arrival*: A large number (the exact number is disputed, but it's between 5 and 50 thousand) of interdimensional invaders (Karath) enter through the rift. The Karath are a warlike civilization of aliens resembling humanoids, twice as tall as humans, and shrouded in moving shadows. The Karath are permanently attuned to the Wake and have several powerful innate abilities including telepathy and telekinesis. They can also influence humans and animals, even at a short distance, to become mindless husks or *ghouls* that obey their every command.

Year 0-39: *The Invasion*: The Karath immediately pursue a wildly successful campaign of conquest against the denizens of Earth. Governments are quickly overthrown, and the Karath use their powers to take control of huge armies, turning people and animals alike into mindless swarms of rabid spawn that obey their masters' commands. The Karath are nicknamed "demons".

Year 1: Humans develop Totems, small trinkets that act as wards against the demon's ghoulfication ability.

Year 2: The first human Whisper attunes to the Wake, and seeing a vision of humanity's future, leads a group of powerful warriors and scholars to

Longyearbyen, a small mining town in Svalbard, where he erects the first Warding Wall around the town.

Year 3: The rift abruptly closes, leaving the demons stranded with no way to return to their home-dimension of Vel. The temperature across the planet peaks at four degrees above pre-industrial levels. Crop failures across the planet cause mass starvation. Demons roam the planet and key straits are closed due to demonic activity as whales and sharks are ghoulished.

Year 4: The Bjørnøya Resource Group dissolves and Bear Island is abandoned.

Year 5: The United States collapses and fractures into warring states. The Russian Federation breaks apart when Moscow falls to a demon army, leaving regions to fend for themselves. Regions within Europe become isolationist, closing their borders and building defensive walls.

Year 7: Rural areas in the north that rely heavily on imports to survive depopulate. Survivalist communities in Alaska and northern Canada develop their own versions of Warding Walls to combat marauding demon armies.

Year 8: A demon raid on Longyearbyen is repelled at great cost, and when the mayor is killed in the attack, the first Whisper is announced as city Elder.

Year 9: News of the demons' defeat at Longyearbyen triggers a huge wave of migration as people make the long journey north to safety. As the city grows, its nickname "Polaris" is adopted as the official city name because people use the north star (Polaris) to navigate to Svalbard.

Year 11: Overcrowding in Polaris spills out past the Warding Wall. Ghettos outside the wall become unmanageable, despite best efforts.

Year 15: Construction of a massive, outer Warding Wall around Polaris begins.

Year 17: *Slaughter at the Wall:* A demon attack kills thousands of refugees outside the wall. Many refugees lose hope in the Elder and travel to an abandoned scientific outpost in the west, building their own defensive ramparts and naming it Fort Barren.

Year 20: One of the Elder's circle leads refugees to the city of Pyramiden, renaming it "Monument" and building a small Warding Wall.

Year 22: Construction of the Warding Wall finishes in Polaris.

Year 24: Monument is almost completely wiped out by a demon attack.

Year 25: Fort Barren holds off a demon attack with help from Polaris.

Year 28: Polaris, Monument, and Fort Barren form the Union of Polar Cities (U.P.C.), a trade agreement and defensive alliance against demon attacks.

Year 29: It's discovered that Greenland has turned into a toxic lake as it thawed. Expeditions to Iceland find small, isolated pockets of survivors.

Year 30: Relations between the Canadian Nunavut and the U.P.C. are established. Trade and knowledge are exchanged.

Year 33: The city of *Murmansk* establishes trade contacts with Polaris. They have their own Warding Wall, but relations beyond trade are strained: Murmansk is ruled by a militaristic dictatorship that uses draconian laws to root out potential demons hiding in their community.

Year 35: The population of Polaris reaches 100,000. Combined, the polar cities have a population of about 200,000.

Year 38: The Elder passes away in his sleep. **Does everyone agree how he died? What are some theories people have?**

Year 38: The Elder's daughter *Helda* is unanimously elected to be the new Elder by a council of representatives from the three polar cities. She declares the polar cities the *Arctic League* and arranges for representatives from the cities to join her in Polaris to discuss trade, development, and defense. In the following years, policy-making and strategic planning becomes consolidated in Polaris, which grows a large bureaucratic district.

Year 48: Helda retires after ten years and a new Elder is elected, a scientist named *Brann*. He becomes known for sending out more expeditions and for his knowledge of pre-Cataclysm geography.

Year 61: The population of Polaris reaches 150,000. Combined, the cities of the Arctic League has a population of about 250,000.

Year 65: Ursa City is founded by Polaris explorers on Bear Island as a mining colony when the pre-Cataclysm B.R.G. mining robots are found and put to work. A Warding Wall is erected all the way around the island at the top of its cliffs.

Year 86: As the defacto trade-hub between Murmansk and Polaris, Ursa City's merchant class quickly becomes very wealthy. The Ursa Corporation emerges

as a new faction based out of Ursa City, a trade consortium responsible for managing all goods that pass through the city.

Year 90: Murmansk overthrows its dictatorship and enters a period of revolutionary turmoil as their new elected government struggles with the more extreme elements of its movement.

Year 91: Elder Brann retires. Elder *Steig* is elected, a member of the merchant class. He is a wise but cautious ruler.

Year 98: Murmansk establishes an oligarchy, now ruled by elected members of their powerful industrial leaders.

Year 103: Vegetation on Svalbard begins to shift as the glaciers on the south-side of the island melt. Trees, and even fruit begin grow in the Meltwater region.

Year 105: Cautiously, a new city is founded in the Meltwater region: Svea. Its Warding Wall is constructed by *Karla*, a scientist and Whisper. Within a few years, Svea becomes a critical source of food for the other regions, as its fertile soil produces birch trees, berry bushes, root vegetables, and the first fruit orchards anyone who is alive has seen.

Year 118: *New Frontiers:* After the success of Svea, new towns are established by eager settlers on the Isle of Aren. Among them, the township of Grima, built on the remnants of a pre-Cataclysm scientific outpost. In their eagerness, these settlements don't bother fortifying.

Year 121: The settlement of Kingsby is established in the Fjordlands by fishers and spawn-hunters. They quickly become experts at customizing their Skyships for speed and hunting demon-spawn. **What's the point of hunting demon-spawn? Resources? Why would they go north instead of to the fertile areas?**

Year 124: *The Blight War:* The Blight attacks Svalbard but is turned back with help from allies in Nunavut and Murmansk.

- The horde is huge, a force of at least 100,000 ghouls and other demon-spawn.
- Grima and the other cities on Aren Island are destroyed during an attack by a huge horde of demon-spawn.
- *The Siege of Polaris:* The Demon and his Blight besieges Polaris, but can't get past the Warding Wall. Despite best efforts from other

cities, the enemy force is too strong and the siege continues for three weeks.

- Heeding the Elder's call for help, Nunavut bear battalions arrive and charge the besieging horde.
- Heeding the Elder's call for help, Murmansk sends its merchant skyfleet to drop explosives onto demon-spawn from above.
- *The Battle of Polaris*: Between the Nunavut reinforcements, Murmansk merchant fleet, and the armies of the polar cities, the demon leading the Blight is slain by a Monument warrior, Osren Pale. He is immediately celebrated as a hero.
- A hundred thousand soldiers and civilians die in the battle.

Year 126: Elder Steig and his allies in the polar council pass a resolution to ban all further settlements, instead encouraging tiered building in the poorer neighborhoods of the city to allow for population growth.

Year 129: A political faction, the Reclaimers, grows out of dissatisfaction with the Elder's reluctance to establish new settlements. This faction is present in every city, but especially in Polaris.

Year 130: The population of Polaris reaches 300,000. Combined, the polar cities have a population of about 500,000. The immigration waves from the south have mostly petered out at this point.

Year 133: The B.R.G. portal key is discovered in Ursa City. The portal itself is unknown, somewhere deep below caved-in tunnels under the city.

Year 138: The ruling government relaxes their rules on new settlements in order to make concessions to the Reclaimers. New settlements, however, must be approved by Elder on a case-by-case basis.

Year 141: No settlement requests are approved by Elder Steig, who insists on very thorough planning and research.

Year 142: *End of the League, beginning of the Empire*: Elder Steig is murdered on the council floor by several Reclaimers. Politician and member of the Reclaimers, Erlan Fenn, declares himself *Polar Emperor* of the polar cities. The Arctic League is dissolved and the Polar Empire is born.

Year 142-146: *Polar Civil War*: Each Polar City officially joins the Polar Empire.

- Monument and Kingsby immediately swear allegiance and integrate their governments.
- Svea holds out until 146, when relations break down and Svea withholds food after Emperor Fenn insists they swear fealty. Monument and Polaris shock troops enter Svea and force the city's matriarch, Karla, to kneel to the Emperor. In the skirmish, Fort Barren's visiting dignitary, crown prince Vasek, is killed by Polaris troops when he attempts to defend Karla. Karla is imprisoned in a prison in Ursa City, and her young daughter Nora is put in charge of the city. Karla is essentially held hostage to make Nora cooperate with the Emperor in Polaris.
- Fort Barren's ruling class protests against the treatment of the Sveans, but ultimately fold.
- Ursa City negotiates to join the Empire peacefully in exchange for very loose control from Polaris. They enter an advantageous trade agreement.
- The portal key is bestowed to Elder Steig in Polaris as a gift.

Year 144-168: An exodus of Homesteaders move from Polaris and Monument with the intention of starting new lives in Meltwater.

Year 148: Reclaimers, rebranded as Royalists, impose a restrictive passport law to prevent the cities from becoming depopulated. The aftermath of the Blight War left scattered remnants of the Blight's army in Meltwater and the Heartlands, so most of the settlers move to Svea instead of forming new towns.

Year 155: Sisters of the Wake, a group of Svean Whispers, attempt to assassinate the Emperor when he visits Svea. Hundreds die in an attuning accident when the attempt goes wrong, and Imperial troops corner the Sisters at a **religious place** and kill them. Emperor Fenn passes a decree that all Whispers must be registered in Polaris by the age of sixteen.

Year 156: *The Mandate* is formed: an organization responsible for training and licensing Whispers. The Mandate is run by *Paladins*, who enforce the Mandate within the walls of the Anchor, a massive stone structure with a Warding Wall design, created to suppress any attunement within.

Year 159: Emperor Fenn passes a decree that all trade between cities must happen through Polaris, and must pay a trade tax. **Why?**

Year 160: Tensions between Polaris, Monument, and Fort Barren rise. Fort Barren still holds a grudge for the killing of their prince. Polaris never delivered on promised trade concessions or seats on the Imperial Court to Monument.

Year 167: The city of Freehaven is illegally established on Edge Island by a group of homesteaders (among them, Whispers looking to escape persecution in the Empire). The settlement flourishes, and is left in peace by the Empire as many of the emperor's advisors have business interests in the Freehaven (that they couldn't do in Polaris).

- Freehaven is a place of opportunity for want-to-be homesteaders who can scrape together money for a passport (or a forgery)
- It is also a place of lawlessness and crime as illicit businesses use the unique political situation to their advantage (e.g., illegal or embarrassing Syndicate deals, hiring mercenaries, scientific or Wake experiments, smuggling).
- Homesteads in Freehaven have individual Warding Walls usually erected by unlicensed Whispers.

Year 168: Despite the passport laws restricting freedom of movement, the population of Polaris falls below 300,000 as a result of an exodus of homesteaders leaving for the Meltwater region. Combined, the polar cities have a population of about 700,000. Svea's population is now 200,000. Emperor Fenn imposes a travel ban across the Empire, citing "security concerns".

Year 170: When the mining robots on Bear Island begin to fail, the Ursa Corporation seeks a new source of labor. Locals on Bear Island aren't miners, and the conditions the robots worked in result in high mortality for humans, so the Ursa Corporation starts hiring indentured servants from Freehaven. Mining output goes down nevertheless, so the Corporation starts delving into less reputable businesses (human trafficking, drugs, protection rackets). The Corporation becomes known by another name: the Ursa Syndicate (or just, the Syndicate).

Year 180: The Syndicate backs Mayor Jarven in Ursa City, who wins the election in a landslide. The new Mayor immediately passes a series of reforms easing restrictions on the Syndicate's business interests. This marks the Syndicate's final step towards complete control of Ursa City.

Year 182: After uncovering some old B.R.G. labs, the Syndicate begins cybernetic experiments on kidnapped Freehaven homesteaders.

Year 184: The first Syndicate mining husks (modified humans) are deployed in the Bear Island mines. Kidnappings accelerate.

Year 185: Murmansk is besieged and falls to a demon and his horde only three days. It's unclear why their Warding Walls don't hold. Many merchants and skyships escape in the Murmansk exodus, but the majority of the city's population is turned into ghouls. Most of them travel to Polaris and Ursa City. A "lower city" is established in the upper levels of the Ursa City mines where the Syndicate places refugees from Murmansk, offering them "work" to fuel their mining operations (by turning some of them into husks).

Year 186: Ghettos form within Polaris as the city struggles to support the refugees from Murmansk. Many want to travel to Svea and Freehaven, but lack the travel papers to leave the city.

Year 189: Karla, the former Svean matriarch, dies imprisoned in Ursa City. Ursa City refuses to release her body but Svea holds a state funeral anyway, and the Matriarch Nora calls for a month of mourning in honor of her mother. Tensions flare in Svea and protests erupt against the Emperor.

Year 193: Fort Barren and Monument agree to establish trade relations with each other, bypassing the Imperial trade decree. The meeting between King Karaul of Fort Barren and Mayor Astrid of Monument takes place in Freehaven. The Emperor is sick and his advisors act in his stead, and in order to not make tensions worse they pretend it was the Emperor's idea.

Year 196: *Lower City Uprising:* The inhabitants of the Lower City on Bear Island stop cooperating with the Syndicate, cutting off the manpower for the mines. In response, the lower city is sealed off from Ursa City except for the entrance to the deeper mines. Only about 30% of the manpower in the mines is robots now, the rest are mining husks, "enhanced" humans. To replenish their manpower, the Syndicate constructs a flagship, the Hand of Sorrow, for the express purpose of raiding Freehaven and creating husks.

Year 197: The Emperor dies, leaving his two sons. The Imperial Court is thrown into disarray, as both sons insist they are the rightful heirs.

Year 198: The cities of the Polar Empire turn inward toward their own politics as the Polar Empire threatens to fracture without leadership. The Imperial Court is in a standstill.

- Freehaven denounces Ursa City and begins to militarize in order to respond to repeated raids on its homesteads.

- Representatives from Svea refuse to attend the Court as Polaris demands higher shipments of food to supply the city.
- Fort Barren?
- Kingsby?
- Monument?
- Ursa City?

Year 199: Current year: The Hand of Sorrow is on its way back from Freehaven after raiding a homestead. The *Player* finds themselves on it (and their origin story defines how that happened). Also on board are Casseopeia (Svean Matriarch Nora's daughter) and Lyra (Casseopeia's bodyguard). The Hand of Sorrow is attacked by a demon and a group of ghouls on its way to Ursa City. This marks the start of the game's story.